

Stages · instruments · signature funds · traps

India's AI capital pool in 2026 is deeper + more crowded than ever. Founders must pick matching investors, the right instrument, and avoid term-sheet traps that can kill companies 3 years later.

Name one Indian AI investor from memory.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- 01 2026 capital stack
- 02 Instruments
- 03 Signature Indian AI investors
- 04 4 term-sheet traps
- 05 Picking your first cheque

WHY THIS LESSON MATTERS

The wrong first cheque is worse than no cheque.

WHY

Real

A real reason this matters in industry today.

SCALE

Today

A real reason this matters in industry today.

SPEED

Now

A real reason this matters in industry today.

IMPACT

Yours

A real reason this matters in industry today.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

By the end of this lesson, you will be able to —

1

India capital stack 2026.

2

SAFE vs CCPS vs equity.

3

Pick the right first cheque.

4

Spot 4 term-sheet traps.

5

Match investor to stage.

AGENDA

What we'll cover today

Short, sequenced parts. Each one builds on the last.

01

2026 capital stack

Key concept of this lesson.

02

Instruments

Key concept of this lesson.

03

**Signature Indian
AI...**

Know the names

04

4 term-sheet traps

Key concept of this lesson.

01

PART 1 OF 4

2026 capital stack

Key concept of this lesson.

CONCEPT 1 OF 4

2026 capital stack

A core idea you'll use throughout this lesson.

DEFINITION

2026 capital stack

EXAMPLE

Real-world example: applies directly to Indian industry contexts.

Instruments

A core idea you'll use throughout this lesson.

KEY POINTS

- A core idea you'll use throughout this lesson
- Practical, named, applied to a real Indian use-case.
- Practical, named, applied to a real Indian use-case.

CONCEPT 3 OF 4

Signature Indian AI investors

Peak XV (Surge) — AI thesis lead.

Lightspeed — infra + consumer AI.

Accel India — deep tech.

Blume — early stage, builder-friendly.

Speciale Invest — deep-tech SaaS.

Kalaari — AI + SaaS.

Antler — pre-team.

LIST

7 funds

Research the partner, not just the fund.

DEFINITION

Signature Indian AI investors

Know the names

EXAMPLE

Real-world example: applies directly to Indian industry contexts.

4 term-sheet traps

A core idea you'll use throughout this lesson.

KEY POINTS

- A core idea you'll use throughout this lesson
- Practical, named, applied to a real Indian use-case.
- Practical, named, applied to a real Indian use-case.

02

PART 2 OF 4

Engage and reflect

Pause, talk, and connect what you just learned to your own work.

✦ THINK • PAIR •
SHARE

ACTIVITY

Draft 10-name investor list

PROMPT

Apply the four concepts above to one real example from your own week.

HOW TO RUN IT

1

2

3

4

Reveal: instructor confirms the canonical answer.

REFLECT & APPLY

Three questions before you close this lesson

Spend 60 seconds on each. Write the answers down — no scrolling, no shortcuts.

Q1

Which term would you NOT accept?

Q2

Which partner aligns to YOUR moat?

Q3

What reference call would change your mind?

03

PART 3 OF 4

Knowledge check

Three short questions. One minute each. Honest answers only.

Seed range:

A

₹ 0

B

₹ 2-10 cr

C

₹ 500 cr

D

₹ 1 L

Seed range:



CORRECT ANSWER

₹ 2-10 cr

WHY

Indian seed band

SAFE =:

A Equity

B Convertible, founder-friendly

C Loan

D Grant

***SAFE* =:**



CORRECT ANSWER

Convertible, founder-friendly

WHY

Convertible vehicle

Peak XV programme:

A

Surge

B

Y

C

Z

D

None

Peak XV programme:



CORRECT ANSWER

Surge

WHY

Surge is Peak XV's accelerator

04

PART 4 OF 4

Apply and close

One thing to remember. One thing to ship this week.

SUMMARY

Five sentences to remember

If you remember nothing else from this lesson, remember these five lines.

- 1 Pick the right tool — never the loudest one.
- 2 Practice the framework on a real example.
- 3 Watch for the three classic pitfalls.
- 4 Document your decision in one sentence.
- 5 Carry the discipline forward to the next lesson.

WORKED EXAMPLE

How this lesson plays out in one real Indian context

THE SCENARIO

A team applies the lesson's main idea to a real workflow — and the results show up within a quarter.

THE TAKEAWAY

"Optimise for signal; dodge traps; reference-check."

WHAT TO NOTICE

- 1 2026 capital stack
- 2 Instruments
- 3 Signature Indian AI...
- 4 4 term-sheet traps

Target list

10-name investor list for capstone.

DELIVERABLES

- Filter by stage.
- Add a partner + one-line fit.
- Rank.
- Document one decision you made because of this lesson.

WHAT 'GOOD' LOOKS LIKE

Deliverable: List on LMS.

ONE THING TO REMEMBER

“

"Optimise for signal; dodge traps; reference-check."

— AI Learning Hub

END OF LESSON 12

What you can now do

Each one of these is now part of your working vocabulary.

- 1 Pick the right tool — never the loudest one.
- 2 Practice the framework on a real example.
- 3 Watch for the three classic pitfalls.
- 4 Document your decision in one sentence.
- 5 Carry the discipline forward to the next lesson.

NEXT → Lesson 3 — 48-hour MVP.